Life on the ship was rather easygoing. I wangled myself a job as a typist and once again didn't pull duty. I spent most of my time reading and eating (the sailors fed themselves well) and watching movies. The high point, as I recall, came when I managed to liberate an entire frosted layer cake out of the kitchen, then sat in a secluded corner of the deck watching a movie while I ate the entire thing very slowly.

Then, on May 13, 1946, when I had been on the Cortland for two weeks, something very unexpected happened. I received a letter from Gertrude, telling me that her allotment had not arrived and that when she called to inquire, they told her that the allotment had been stopped because her husband (me!) had been discharged.

The allotment was $50 a month, and I didn't want it stopped. Worse, what if my application for discharge back in February had been approved and I had never been informed?

The next day I got off the ship, despite the protests of the officer in charge of us. (A stopped allotment is a serious thing, and I was able to outindignation him.) I then went from officer to officer, at each stop demanding that either Gertrude get her allotment if I were still in the Army, or that I be sent back home if I were not. I also hinted that I was in a peculiar position since my wife must believe that I was out of the Army and that nonappearance at home might be very suspicious from the marital standpoint.

I finally worked my way up to Colonel Jordan, who was in charge of all Army operations. He was a rather stout man, who impressed me as a rather good-natured, long suffering fellow.

He listened to the story, and said, "But how can you possibly have been discharged?"

"I don't know, sir, but that's what my wife was told. Here's her letter/'

"You never applied for discharge, did you?"

"Yes, I did, sir. On February 11, I applied for a research discharge under Order 363."

He spread his arms. "Well, it's probably some mixup but it's against Crossroads policy to send anyone to Bikini who may be subject to discharge. I may have to take you off the project."